W. Matthew Alampay Davis

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Department of Economics
Columbia University
New York, NY 10027

Education

Columbia University	University of Oxford	New York University
Dept. of Economics, GSAS	Nuffield College	Stern School of Business
Ph.D Economics (2025)	*M.Phil* Economics (2019)	*B.Sc* Business & Political Economy (2015)

Research

Development Economics · Environmental/Climate economics · Political Economy

Job market paper

Climate inequality

Work in progress

Political transition under environmental stress

Economic disruption, cultural anti-persistence, and intimate-partner violence
with Tanushree Goyal

Elite capture and identity politics: A formal model of substantive representation

Publications

Large potential reduction in economic damages under UN mitigation targets
with Marshall Burke, Noah S. Diffenbaugh — *Nature* (2018)

We present a probabilistic framework for assessing aggregate economic impacts of anthropogenic warming. Our construction decomposes uncertainty associated with mid-century and end-of-century GDP projections into error associated with i) econometric estimation of the economic effects of environmental change, ii) climate models of the spatial distribution of anthropogenic warming, iii) the projected schedule of greenhouse gas concentrations associated with radiative forcings, and iv) the social discounting regime of choice. We apply this framework to characterize the economic benefits of climate policy, emphasizing how achieving the most ambitious mitigation targets of the 2015 Paris Agreement would obviate essentially certain economic calamity concentrated in developing countries.

Combining satellite imagery and machine learning to predict poverty
with Neal Jean, Marshall Burke, Michael Xie, David B. Lobell, Stefano Ermon — *Science* (2016)

We demonstrate a scalable method to address the scarcity and prohibitive expense of collecting disaggregated welfare data in the developing world by extracting economic information from an unconventional but abundant data source with increasingly frequent and near-global coverage: daytime satellite photography. Our "transfer learning" pipeline proceeds by first assigning a convolutional neural network model pre-trained for generic image classification the task of identifying features in georeferenced satellite images predictive of night-time luminosity, a crude proxy for economic activity. In effect, the CNN learns to produce a nonlinear mapping from high-resolution unstructured image data to low-dimensional vector representations of their most economically relevant features. Ridge regression models are then trained on survey data to refine the feature selection for out-of-sample predictive performance. In an exploratory application to five diverse sub-Saharan African countries—Nigeria, Tanzania, Uganda, Malawi, and Rwanda—our open-source models trained on publicly available data are found to explain up to 75% of the variation in village-level consumption and asset wealth measured by traditional household surveys.

Referee service

Journal of Development Economics

Teaching

Graduate Teaching Fellow at Columbia University (nine semesters, 2020–2024)
Research consultant to all UG/MA economics thesis writers and research assistants
ECON-4999 – Senior honors thesis workshops (design and instruction)
ECON-3412 – Introduction to econometrics (TA)
ECON-3211 – Intermediate microeconomics (TA)
ECON-2257 – The global economy (TA)

Past affiliations

Research associate at Climate Econometrics (2017–2019)
Nuffield College, University of Oxford
supervised by David F. Hendry, Elizabeth Baldwin

Pre-doctoral scholar at Center on Food Security and the Environment (2015–2017)
Dept. of Earth System Science, Stanford University
supervised by Marshall Burke, David Lobell

Honors

Program for Economic Research Summer Fellowship (2024)
Columbia economics department award supporting summer research activities

Wueller Fourth-Year Pre-Dissertation Award (2023)
Columbia economics department runner-up best dissertation proposal

UC Berkeley and Sloan Foundation Diversity Fellowship (2022)
Awarded to five doctoral students in environmental and energy economics

Columbia GSAS Dean's Fellowship and Dissertation Fellowship (2019)
Full-tuition scholarship and living stipend for up to six years of graduate study at Columbia

Oxford M.Phil top-scoring economics thesis (2019)
Department's first 'exceptional' (mark of 80+) thesis in at least four years

Nuffield College–Department of Economics Joint Studentship (2017)
Full-tuition scholarship and living stipend for up to four years of graduate study at Oxford

References

Administrators

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Personal

Background Philippines (nationality) · Indonesia (13 years) · Vietnam

Study and career United States · United Kingdom · China

Immediate family Philippines · Australia · Canada